

# Expert Grammaticality Judges Are Evaluators, Not Participants

Grammaticality Judgments, Rater Roles, and Human-Subjects Review

Brett Reynolds \*

Humber Polytechnic & University of Toronto

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## Abstract

Expert judgments of grammaticality are often discussed as though they were responses from research participants. That treatment is too coarse. When a linguist is asked to evaluate linguistic materials in virtue of professional competence, the role is closer to that of an essay scorer, translation reviewer, coding adjudicator, or psychometric rater than to that of a participant whose own behaviour, attitudes, or cognitive processing are the target of study. This paper argues for a role-sensitive distinction between participant data and expert evaluation in grammaticality research. The distinction does not remove ordinary obligations of transparency, consent, conflict management, or local ethics review where required. It instead clarifies what the evidence is evidence of: not a sample of speaker reactions, but a disciplined expert assessment of linguistic materials under stated standards.

Keywords: grammaticality judgments; expert judgment; rater effects; linguistic methodology; research ethics

## I THE PROBLEM

Expert grammaticality judgments occupy an unstable methodological category. In one description, such judgments are human responses to linguistic stimuli and therefore look like participant data. In another, such judgments are scholarly evaluations of linguistic materials and therefore look like expert ratings, editorial judgments, coding decisions, or psychometric scoring. The paper starts from that role ambiguity.

The proposed answer is not that expert judgment is exempt from scrutiny. The answer is that the scrutiny should be role-sensitive. A judge can be a participant when the research question concerns that person's reaction, processing, background, social identity, or judgment distribution. But a judge can also be an evaluator when the research question concerns the linguistic status of an item and the person's expertise is used to assess the item against disciplinary standards.

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\*Contact: [brett.reynolds@humber.ca](mailto:brett.reynolds@humber.ca)

The target claim is narrow: expert judges of grammaticality should not automatically be treated as study participants merely because their judgments are human acts. The first question is what role their judgment plays in the evidential design.

## 2 PARTICIPANTS, INFORMANTS, AND EVALUATORS

The central distinction is between producing data about oneself and applying expertise to a target object. A participant contributes evidence about a population of people, a psychological process, a distribution of acceptability, a demographic contrast, or an intervention effect. An evaluator contributes an assessment of an object: an essay, a translation, a diagnosis, a code, a performance, or a linguistic example.

This distinction is functional rather than honorific. Calling someone an evaluator does not make the judgment infallible, unregulated, or methodologically private. It changes the evidential question. The relevant issues become qualification, calibration, independence, adjudication, documentation, and conflict of interest, not sampling, participant burden, demographic representativeness, or the protection of private personal data.

For grammaticality work, the distinction matters because many expert judgments do not estimate speaker-preference distributions. The task is to decide whether a proposed sentence, construction, contrast, or diagnostic behaves as the theory says it does. That use of expertise is evaluative.

## 3 THE ESSAY-EVALUATOR ANALOGY

Educational and psychometric studies routinely distinguish the people whose performances are measured from the people who score those performances. Essay scorers, rubric raters, and adjudicators can introduce error, bias, drift, and disagreement. That does not make them participants in the same sense as the students whose essays are being evaluated.

The analogy is useful because it keeps two truths together. First, expert evaluators are part of the measurement apparatus and need to be reported as such. Second, the object of study is still the target material, not the evaluator's personal response unless the design says otherwise. In a grammaticality paper, an expert judge may function like a trained rater whose decision bears on the status of an item.

The analogy also blocks a bad inference. If raters can be unreliable, one should model, train, blind, rotate, adjudicate, or report that unreliability. One should not therefore collapse rater evaluation into participant sampling.

## 4 WHAT EXPERT GRAMMATICALITY JUDGMENTS DO

Expert grammaticality judgments can serve several roles. They can screen examples, test diagnostic contrasts, adjudicate corpus candidates, check paraphrases, evaluate minimal pairs, or assess whether a constructed item successfully isolates the intended variable. These are not the same role as estimating how a population would rate the sentence on a Likert scale.

The methodological burden is correspondingly different. An expert-judgment design should say what qualifies the judge, what the judge was asked to evaluate, what information was available, whether judgments were independent, how disagreements were handled, and whether the judgment bears on form, meaning, register, dialect, processing difficulty, or theoretical classification.

Level discipline matters here. A grammaticality claim, an acceptability-distribution claim, a processing claim, and a social-distribution claim are different claims. Treating every expert judgment as participant data blurs those levels instead of protecting them.

## 5 WHEN JUDGES ARE PARTICIPANTS

The evaluator role has boundaries. If the study asks how linguists respond, how expertise changes judgments, how quickly people process a contrast, how dialect background affects acceptability, or how training changes ratings, then the judges belong to the target population. In such cases, the design studies their responses as responses, so they function as participants or participant-like contributors.

The same person can also move between roles. A linguist who privately checks an example for a colleague may be an evaluator. The same linguist in an experiment comparing expert and non-expert ratings is a participant. The ethical and methodological classification follows the study role, not the person's professional title.

The paper should therefore resist both overreach and special pleading. Expertise does not exempt a study from human-participant review when the human is the object of inquiry. But neither does the mere presence of human expertise convert every scholarly evaluation into participant research.

## 6 REPORTING AND ETHICS

The practical proposal is a reporting distinction. Participant studies should report recruitment, eligibility, consent, demographics where relevant, compensation, exclusion, and statistical treatment of responses. Expert-evaluation studies should report evaluator qualifications, evaluation task, independence, access to context, adjudication procedure, disagreement handling, and any relationship between evaluator and author.

The institutional claim needs care. Local research-ethics boards decide the scope of their own review, and the paper should not pretend to settle law or policy by definition. The argument is methodological and conceptual: ethics review should not be triggered by the word "judgment" alone. The relevant question is whether the project studies persons as persons, or uses professional evaluation to assess linguistic materials.

This distinction can improve ethics practice rather than weaken it. It routes real participant studies to participant protections and routes expert-evaluation studies to transparency, independence, conflict-management, and measurement-quality standards.

## 7 CONCLUSION

Expert grammaticality judgments should be classified by evidential role. When the research target is a population of judgments, an effect on judges, or the social distribution of acceptability, judges are participants. When the target is the linguistic status of materials and expert judgment is used to evaluate those materials, judges are evaluators.

The payoff is methodological hygiene. It lets grammaticality research be transparent about expert judgment without pretending that every expert consultation is a human-participant study. The right analogy is often not the survey respondent but the essay scorer: a fallible, reportable, calibratable evaluator whose work affects measurement quality.

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